

Palm Zire 21

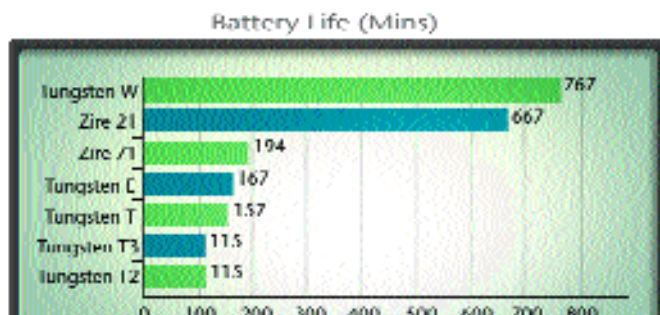
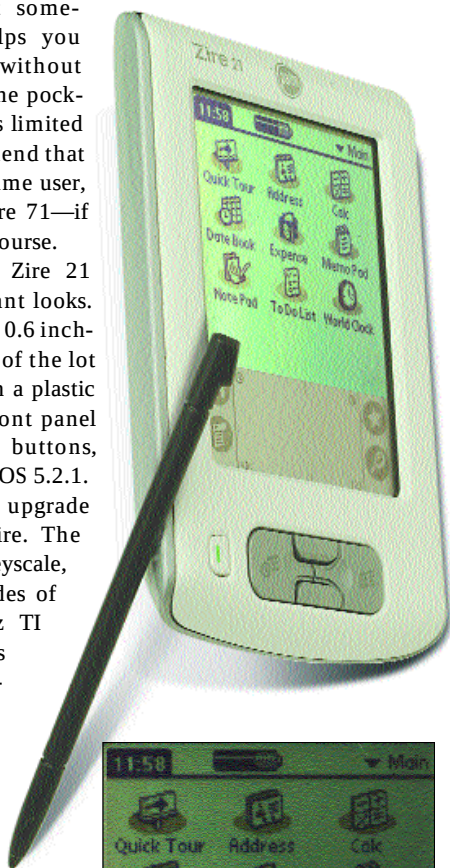
The Palm Zire 21 is ideal if you just want something that helps you organise your life, without being too heavy on the pocket. But considering its limited features, we'd recommend that even if you're a first-time user, you should buy a Zire 71—if you can afford it, of course.

Design-wise, the Zire 21 sports plain, yet elegant looks. It measures 4.4 x 2.9 x 0.6 inches, and is the lightest of the lot at 108 gm. Encased in a plastic body, with a white front panel and grey application buttons, the device runs Palm OS 5.2.1.

It's a significant upgrade from the original Zire. The screen is 160 x 160 greyscale, and displays 16 shades of grey. The 126 MHz TI OMAP311 processor is probably over-powered for most applications you're likely to use on the Zire 21.

Going by the features provided, you'll use the

The Zire 21's 160 x 160 greyscale screen does not have a backlight.



device mostly for its PIM functionality, so the 7.2 MB of user-available storage should be more than enough to store your contacts, to-dos and notes.

It's an ergonomically good device. There's no backlight, however, so you can't view the display in the dark. The internal battery lasted us a cool 11 hours and seven minutes.

There's no card expansion slot and no universal connector either, which puts expansion capabilities at zero. In terms of connectivity, you only get Infra-red to pair it with a compatible device. There's no cradle, and the internal battery can be charged through the provided AC adapter. The battery also charges when it's connected to a PC through a USB port.

The Zire 21 comes with standard Personal Information Manager (PIM) applications including Date Book, Address, Calculator, To-do, Notepad and World Clock. You also get other useful applications such as Handmark's MobileDB, Handmark PDA Money, Palm Reader, PowerOne Personal Calculator and Handmark's MagicDogs Playing Cards.

Palm Zire 21

A-

- + Economical
- Lacks features
- Price:** Rs 7,249

Performance	▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶
Features	▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶
Ergonomics	▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶
Value for money	▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶

How We Tested

The complete range of Palm OS-based PDAs was tested on the parameters of features, performance, battery life and ergonomics. The weightages allotted were 55 per cent for features, and 15 per cent each for the rest. In features, we looked for connectivity options, screen capabilities, memory and media playback capabilities, as well as special features such as an integrated camera and keyboard, among others.

To test performance, we used Benchmark 2.0, PilotMark and Speedy 3.3. Benchmark 2.0 performed the CPU and memory-intensive Fibonacci calculation test,

and provided a percentage score relative to the Palm Ilie.

PilotMark showed the time taken by the device to read, write and copy 1 MB of data. Speedy 3.3 tested the CPU, memory and graphics, and gave a score relative to the Palm Vx.

To test battery life, we set the screen brightness and volume to 50 per cent, and played a movie trailer, looping continuously until the battery died.

Ergonomics took into account button placement and tactile feel, how easy the device was to hold and use, and so on.

